

What kind of Buyer are you?

The demanding buyer

It's a very simple decision for you: you like the very best, cost be damned! You want the latest processor under your computer's hood, coupled with the most powerful graphics card and exotic peripherals such as alien-esque game controllers, blazing CD-RW drives, optical mice, etc. You corroborate specifications of hardware with review sites on the Internet and read every computer magazine in sight. You know your GeForce 4 from your GeForce 3 and know how to get it too!

Possible pitfalls: You often expect more than what your budget allows. Since you're trying to fit the best into your budget, beware of assemblers trying to sell you sub-specification devices. If you've paid for the fastest 40 GB IDE drive, make sure it is a 7,200-rpm drive and not a 5,400-rpm drive. Since you're spending a lot of money on exotic hardware, demand warranties on all the devices. Ensure that the assembler uses licensed or OEM versions of software. OEM versions are lower priced than retail software—negotiate with your assembler regarding the overall price of the system and make sure that this includes the cost of the installed software.



ILLUSTRATIONS: Ram

The price-conscious buyer

You are well aware that the tree outside your house will not sprout money to let you buy a Logitech WingMan Extreme Digital joystick. Money is of paramount importance—you will not spend a single paisa more than you have to and will bargain till hoarse on the price of the mouse! You've been to over 20 vendors and meticulously noted down the price for each piece of hardware in their inventory. You've inquired about their prices in

Singapore and Dubai and have an average understanding of them and what they're suited to.

Possible pitfalls: Beware of vendors who try to sell you sub-standard or lower specification hardware. If you've specified the brand, make sure you get exactly that one. Use foreign prices only as a guideline—the scene is completely different after hardware passes through the various tax and custom duties in our country. Since you are on a limited budget, you will not be able to buy a system that has best-of-class processing and graphics power. Settle for one that includes a Duron or Celeron processor with integrated graphics or a card such as the GeForce2 MX 200 or a TNT2.



The confused buyer

You are the light of the assembler's life. Blissfully unaware of the different components, all you know is that you want a computer. You will be the target of the full force of the assembler's marketing babble. Technology buzzwords like Pentium 4, 3D accelerated graphics and 40 GB drives can be baffling—try not to fall prey to the 'an nVidia TNT2 is actually a high-powered graphics card' talk!

Possible pitfalls: You need to look out every step of the way. Beware of eager vendors who insist on closing a deal quickly. Take your time looking around and evaluate how much different vendors are charging you. Do your homework through online sites, other PC-owners and through a survey of different assemblers. The best solution is to take along a 'techie' friend who might know about hardware prices. Or, get a listing of the specifications you would need from a trusted source and then insist on those specifications only. Insist on licensed software and be clear about the after-sales service offered since you'll need it often. Most importantly, see that you have all the documentation with regards to the warranties—verify the type of warranty, the period and what hardware it covers. Remember to have the system checked by a knowledgeable person when it is ready to be delivered to you.



Making the purchase

Once you've decided on which assembler you want to entrust your system to and have finalised on the configuration, it's time for the final step. But before you actually place the order, make sure that you have a clear understanding with the vendor regarding the hardware configuration, warranty, after-sales support and the payment terms. Most vendors accept only cash-down payment, but you should insist on paying a major part of the amount upon satisfactory installation. Also, iron out details regarding the delivery and installation of the system. Make sure that there is a clause

that clearly specifies the date of delivery of the system and that the assembler covers any damage caused to the system during delivery. Plan it such that you personally receive the system and check each and every component upon arrival, all the way from specifications and brand of components, down to the colour! Very often, vendors try to squeeze in surprises at the last minute and refuse to accept a return later. Sign the bill only after you have personally verified that the system is working to your satisfaction and that the specifications match what you had ordered. Also check that the software installed is what you had asked for. If a

PC fails due to faulty components, it usually does so within the first week. Make sure that you have an understanding with your assembler, which allows you to return the system within a certain time-frame after installation in case something goes wrong.

Now that you have the roadmap, buying a PC from your local assembler should be a whole lot simpler. Stick by these ground rules, do the background work, keep a lookout for overzealous vendors and you'll have a system that will stick by you through all your quests in computing. 

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